may be wrong about it altogether. United, we would have stood strong. It would have been good for the team's performance, morale and discipline.

Instead, the opposite happened. Egos clashed. And the people around him, naysayers, like the assistant coach and the bowling coach, started priming him for confrontation. It was unfortunate that we had a falling-out because Waqar Younis is a very, very good man and one of the finest cricketers the game has ever produced.

Wiqi bhai and I are okay now, thank God, but we didn't get here easily. To clear things, he and I had a very important meeting. It was after my comeback series in 2011, when I scored a 75 and took five wickets at Sharjah against Sri Lanka in the fourth ODI of that series. Even though I was injured earlier in the match, I came back that day to become unstoppable with both ball and bat, becoming the first man to score a 50 and get five wickets in a match twice. Mohsin Hassan Khan was coach, and it was he who helped me rebuild my comeback confidence.

In this particular match, after which Wiqi bhai and I made up, I would even become Man of the Match and eventually Man of the Series. Keep in mind that this was still the bitter Ijaz Butt era, and because he and I didn't get along, and because of my controversial stand against the board, there was a lot of scrutiny on me. After the match was over, Waqar, who was commentating for the match, came down to the ground for the presentation. Here, I thought it was the perfect time that God had granted me to apologize and explain myself. So I approached him, we sat down and I asked, 'Wiqi bhai, I have a simple question: do you want to live in the past, or in the future?'

He responded as I had hoped he would respond, 'The future, of course.'

I was upfront about my apology and explained my point of view to him. He heard me out patiently, offered his own apology, put out his hand and we both decided to move forward collectively.

Later, in 2014, I was glad when I found out that he was going to return as Pakistan coach. Before his return, Moin Khan, appointed team manager in 2013, asked me how I would deal with the whole thing, about working with Waqar after all that had happened between us. I said, 'I'm here for Pakistan, and so is Wiqi bhai. There's nothing in my heart against him and I don't think there's anything he holds against me. We will be fine.'

Today, Wiqi bhai and I are indeed fine. And I believe that an honest conversation can truly change anything.

Well, almost everything.

Shoaib Akhtar, at his time the fastest and fiercest bowler in the world, and I, are from the same generation of Pakistan players. We had great times together and I, both as a player and as a captain, backed him whenever he was in trouble – which was quite often. So much so that towards the last years of his controversial career, people like Ijaz Butt and Yawar Saeed didn't even like hearing Shoaib's name spoken out loud – that's how much trouble he was in with the management, mostly due to reports on his personal life, behavioural issues and even temper problems. It seemed as if he was always in the middle of a reputation crisis.

Still, I believed that as a bowler, as a colleague and as a player, Shoaib had to be given a chance, because he was that good and showed immense promise. I tried to support him whenever I could, and went out on a limb for him, irrespective of the consequences for me – like going to war with the board and Ijaz Butt himself. I have no regrets, despite an untoward incident or two